

Tellurium

While selenium is named for the Moon, the next member of the group, tellurium, is named after “tellus”, the Latin word for Earth. It is used to make high-tech glass such as the kind used in optical fibres – a flexible cable with a glass core, which is used to send long-distance light signals.

ATOMIC MASS 127.6

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1783 (Franz-Joseph Müller von Reichenstein)

Laboratory-refined
crystals of pure tellurium



52
Te

Polonium

A rare and very dangerous metal, polonium is a powerful source of deadly radioactivity. It has been used in the triggers for atomic bombs.

ATOMIC MASS
(209)

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY
1898
(Marie Curie)

Uraninite, an
ore of polonium



84
Po

Livermorium

Although first made in the Joint Institute for Nuclear Research (JINR) in the Russian city of Dubna, livermorium was named after Livermore, a town in California, where many other superheavy elements have been created. This element is made by fusing calcium and curium atoms. Its atoms exist for only a few thousandths of a second before breaking apart.

ATOMIC MASS (293)

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 2000 (team led by Yuri Oganessian, Vladimir Utyonkov, and Kenton Moody)

116
Lv